

Japanese Zelkova

Zelkova serrata



Origin

Native to Japan, Taiwan, and parts of eastern China, often planted as a substitute for American elm because of its similar vase-shaped crown.

Look for

Its vase-shaped, upward-arching branch structure closely echoes the American elm's classic silhouette, which is exactly why cities began planting it widely after Dutch elm disease killed so many elms.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Crown: gentle vase shape, branches arching up and outward like a cup -- visible from a block away.
- Leaf: small, toothed, teardrop-shaped leaf.
- Bark: gray with tiny horizontal lenticel marks (breathing pores).
- Commonly confused with: American elm (zelkova's leaves are smaller and it's naturally resistant to Dutch elm disease).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Small toothed leaves emerge along arching branches.
Summer	Dense, rounded-vase crown provides even shade.
Fall	Leaves turn yellow, orange, or reddish-bronze.
Winter	Gray bark with small horizontal lenticel marks is visible on bare branches.

DID YOU KNOW

- Zelkova is in the elm family but is naturally resistant to Dutch elm disease, making it a reliable replacement species.
- In Japan, old zelkova trees are traditionally planted near shrines and are sometimes considered sacred.